

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Carpal Tunnel Syndrome During Pregnancy

Numbness and tingling in the hands is common in pregnancy — and there is a lot we can do about it

WHAT IS CARPAL TUNNEL SYNDROME?

- It happens when a nerve in the wrist — the **median nerve** — is squeezed
- During pregnancy, normal **fluid retention and swelling** place extra pressure on this nerve
- It is common, especially **later in pregnancy**
- It can affect one or both hands

COMMON SYMPTOMS

- Tingling, "pins and needles," burning, or numbness in the **thumb, index, middle, and part of the ring finger**
- Symptoms that are **worse at night** or that wake you from sleep
- Hand or wrist pain
- Swelling or stiffness in the hands
- Weak grip, clumsiness, or dropping objects

WEAR A WRIST SPLINT AT NIGHT

- ✓ A splint that holds your wrist **straight or neutral** reduces pressure on the nerve
- ✓ Wear it **while sleeping** — this is the single most helpful step for most patients
- ✓ If symptoms bother you during the day, we may suggest wearing it for certain activities too
- ✓ Splints are available over the counter; ask us if you are unsure which to buy

ADJUST YOUR ACTIVITIES

- ✓ Take **frequent breaks** from repeated gripping or wrist bending
- ✓ Keep your wrist as **straight as possible** with a phone, keyboard, or steering wheel
- ✓ Avoid sleeping with your wrists **bent under your body or pillow**
- ✓ Change positions often during repetitive hand tasks

REDUCE SWELLING

- ✓ Rest with your hands **elevated on pillows** when you can
- ✓ Gently **open and close your hands** several times through the day
- ✓ Follow your pregnancy care plan for healthy activity, hydration, and nutrition

WILL IT GO AWAY?

- For many patients, symptoms **improve after delivery** as pregnancy swelling goes down
- Symptoms can sometimes **continue after pregnancy**
- Please mention any ongoing numbness, tingling, pain, or weakness at your **postpartum visit**
- We can still treat it after delivery — do not assume you have to live with it

IF CONSERVATIVE MEASURES ARE NOT ENOUGH

- Additional options such as **hand therapy** or a **steroid injection** may be considered when symptoms are significant or do not improve
- Important:** do not start a new medication, supplement, or treatment for hand or wrist pain during pregnancy without discussing it with your obstetric care team first

⚠️ CONTACT OUR OFFICE IF

- ⚠️ Symptoms are severe, constant, or worsening
- ⚠️ You are frequently dropping objects or struggling with daily activities
- ⚠️ Symptoms continue after delivery
- ⚠️ You have weakness in your thumb or hand
- ⚠️ A wrist splint and activity changes are not helping
- ⚠️ You develop sudden swelling of the face or hands, a bad headache, or vision changes

♥️ Simple Steps Help — Start With a Night Splint

Carpal tunnel symptoms in pregnancy can be genuinely miserable, especially when they keep waking you at night. The good news is that simple steps — most of all a night splint — help many patients, and symptoms often ease after delivery. Please tell us if your hands are bothering you, even if it seems minor.